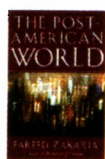


ALTERED STATES

A confirmed modernisation theorist argues that a new world order requires a new American foreign policy



THE POST AMERICAN WORLD

by FAREED ZAKARIA

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■ By Pratap Bhanu Mehta

There is a very good chance that if the designation "post" is used to describe a coming age, all we know is that something is passing, but we are not quite sure what is coming in its wake. For all its fluency, presumptuous ability to generalise on world history and breezy command over international affairs, *The Post American World*, is distinctively an exercise in throwing cold water over the anxieties that shift in global power is generating in the West. Some shift in power towards China and India is inevitable. But fear not, Fareed Zakaria tells his fellow Americans. First, this rise is itself a success of the project of Westernisation; as such it will produce, for good or for ill, more cultural convergence. Second, as the world becomes more independent, countries like China will come to redefine their national interests in ways that are more manageable. Moreover, despite reverses, the trend remains one towards a more peaceful and democratic world.

In fact, Zakaria argues, we are being misled by the mass media, which by focusing on violence happening in different parts of the world, is creating the impression of a world out of joint. But for every violent image, there is a reassuring statistic. Third, that globalisation has, for the most part, been beneficial to the United States as well as to the rest of the world. Fourth, the shift in power will not be as radical as some in the US fear. If the country can stay an open society, the vitality of its culture and the strength of its higher education system that draws the best of the world will see it through. India and China still have a long way to be the kind of place that attract

the best and the brightest, and their internal social challenges will remain formidable. Anti-Americanism is more an aberration than a structural feature of world politics; remove Bush's excesses and the world will return to a nice "we-love-America" equilibrium. The power of consumerism is not to be underestimated: it will inflect Muslim societies as well. They are more likely to be attracted by the dazzle of Dubai than the seminaries of Iran. This optimism is a reassuringly American story.

Zakaria is a brilliant observer of

international affairs, and the book is at its best when it is looking for searching historical analogies rather than giving reassuring generalisations. His comparison of India with 19th century America, with a society stronger than the state and a faltering sense of its own national purposes, is particularly apt. His breezy reflections on India and China are intelligent, if not particularly original. But like much of his writing on the "rise of the rest", the explanation for their rise seems to be ad hominem. It used to be said that culture would be an obstacle to



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